ICC Background Guide - *SOMUN 2026*

Agenda: "Addressing the Challenges and Opportunities Presented by the Rise of Franchise Cricket"

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Letter from the Chair:
Dear Delegates,

Welcome to SOMUN's 8th edition and to the ICC Board Meeting. It is a pleasure to have you with us as we take up the agenda, "Addressing the Challenges and Opportunities Presented by the Rise of Franchise Cricket."

Consider how much a cricketer's choices have changed. Not long ago, wearing your country's colours was the pinnacle of a career, and everything else came second. Today a player can sign a league contract worth more than a full year of national pay, and boards must decide whether to protect their calendars or release their stars. Countries with smaller budgets watch their best players leave for tournaments they cannot match. The sport has grown richer and more global, but also more crowded and more divided. That is the heart of this committee. We are not asking you to declare franchise cricket good or bad. The harder task is to find a way for both versions of the game to thrive, and to agree on who bears the cost when one has to give way.

We expect more from you than rehearsed speeches. Study the numbers behind your own board, league or franchise like what it earns, whom it depends on, and where it has gained or lost

players. Read the cases mentioned in this guide and look for others we have not covered. Then think about the delegates across the room. A wealthy board, an Associate nation, a league commissioner and a franchise owner will each want something different from the same calendar, and a strong resolution will make room for all of them.

Please remember that the ICC cannot simply order leagues around. It does not own most of them, so anything this committee proposes must be something boards and owners are willing to sign up to. In this room, persuasion and compromise will take you further than volume. Deals are made in conversation, so speak to the delegates around you, especially those whose interests differ from yours.

Treat this guide as a starting point, not a finishing line. Ask questions and speak up even if your portfolio has an awkward record on the issue. Owning that record and arguing your way forward is often what people remember most.

We look forward to a thoughtful and spirited session. Argue with conviction, listen with care, and make every intervention count.

Warm regards,
Hasya Reddy
Chairperson, International Cricket Council

About ICC:
The International Cricket Council (ICC) is the international governing body of cricket. It manages the international rules and administration of the game. England, Australia and South Africa founded it in 1909 as the Imperial Cricket Conference. It became the International Cricket Conference in 1965 and the International Cricket Council in 1989. Its headquarters are in Dubai, United Arab Emirates, and it is essentially cricket's equivalent of FIFA. Jay Shah has chaired it since December 2024. Sanjog Gupta became Chief Executive on 7 July 2025, after leading the sports business of the broadcaster JioStar. [1–5]

As of July 2026, the ICC has 111 members: 12 Full Members and 99 Associate Members. Mauritius became the ICC's 111th member in July 2026. Full Members are governing bodies whose representative teams are eligible to play official Test matches. The 12 Full Members are Afghanistan, Australia, Bangladesh, England, India, Ireland, New Zealand, Pakistan, South Africa, Sri Lanka, the West Indies and Zimbabwe. [1–3]

Associate Members are governing bodies for countries or territories where cricket is established and organised, but which do not meet the criteria for Full Membership. Their status, opportunities and access to development support are central to discussions about how franchise cricket can support cricket's global growth without weakening international pathways. For the current membership list, delegates should consult the ICC's official members directory, as membership can change. [2–3]

The ICC is governed by its Board, which sits under an independent Chair and includes an independent director, a director from each of the 12 Full Members, three directors elected by the Associate Members, and the Chief Executive. Its core responsibilities are wide. It lays down the Playing Conditions for international cricket and presides over the ICC Code of Conduct, the Decision Review System (DRS) and its other regulations. It governs the sport's top international tournaments, namely the Men's and Women's Cricket World Cups, the T20 World Cup, the World Test Championship, the U-19 World Cup and the Champions Trophy. It maintains the official team and player rankings in Tests, ODIs and T20Is, and it oversees the Future Tours

Programme, the schedule of bilateral tours that Full Members agree to play. It appoints and trains all the umpires and match referees that officiate at sanctioned international matches, so that officiating is fair and consistent. It also regulates anti-corruption, anti-doping and code-of-conduct enforcement systems, and through its Anti-Corruption Unit it coordinates action against corruption, match-fixing and betting violations. [1, 4]

Beyond regulation, the ICC drives the global growth of the game by funding development programmes in emerging cricket nations and by pushing for the sport's wider recognition, including its return to the Olympic Games at Los Angeles 2028. One important limit applies: the ICC does not regulate bilateral series, which are handled separately by national cricket boards, and it does not own the franchise leagues that now drive so much of cricket's money. That gap between what the ICC regulates and what actually shapes the commercial game is the starting point of this committee's agenda. [4, 5, 7]

Introduction to the Council

This committee simulates the ICC's Annual Council Meeting, adapted to the style of Model United Nations. Delegates do not represent countries, as they would in most MUN committees. Each takes the role of a real decision-maker in the cricketing world: presidents and chairs of national cricket boards, board chief executives, heads of major franchise leagues, and franchise team owners. The council has 32 members, led by an Executive Board made up of the ICC Chair, the ICC Deputy Chair and the ICC General Manager, who serve as Chair, Vice Chair and Rapporteur. The agenda is "Addressing the Challenges and Opportunities Presented by the Rise of Franchise Cricket." [1, 4]

Because boards, leagues and owners sit at the same table, each delegate should represent their organisation's interests, finances and public positions as accurately as possible. A board president has to think about the international calendar and the national team. A league head has to think about the competition's stability and growth. An owner has to think about investment and commercial freedom. Delegates should research their organisation's revenues, disputes, past statements and relationships with other members, and use that research to form alliances, trade concessions and draft workable solutions instead of only restating positions.

When you research, start with primary sources. The ICC's official documents and the published documents of the national cricket boards and leagues are the most reliable record of a position, a rule or a figure. If those do not cover what you need, turn to established cricket reporting, such as ESPNcricinfo, and check important details against a second source. Where reports disagree, work out why before you rely on either.

This background guide is there to help you prepare, but it is not a source you can cite. Please do not quote it, or present its figures as evidence, in speeches, in caucus or in your written work. Use it to find out which topics matter and where to look, then trace each fact you want to use back to an official document or a reliable news report.

The council follows a modified version of the UNA-USA and United Nations rules of procedure. The familiar MUN structure applies. Debate opens with roll call and the setting of the agenda, then moves through a speakers' list into formal debate. Moderated and unmoderated caucuses let delegates focus on specific topics and negotiate and draft in smaller groups. Delegates submit a letter to the council, which will be amended and voted on, and points and motions are raised in the usual way. Because the council consists of boards, leagues and owners and not member states, the Executive Board will explain any changes to the standard rules at the opening session, including how voting works, what counts as a quorum and what a resolution

must contain. The Executive Board's rulings on procedure are final. [SOMUN committee rules; not an external cricket statistic]

The ICC works mostly through negotiation among powerful and very different organisations, and the best outcomes here will balance commercial interests with the long-term health of the sport. Delegates should be formal and respectful, stay creative within their roles, and bring practical proposals on the calendar, player release, revenue sharing, ownership and integrity.

Intro to Agenda:

International cricket, which is made up of multiple formats including tests, one-day internationals, and T20 internationals, is governed by the International Cricket Council along with its member boards. Alongside these developments, a fast-growing franchise sector has emerged in which private-owned teams come together to compete in leagues such as the Indian Premier League, Big Bash League, and SA20. Both draw on the same players and the same calendar, but their interests do not always align. This agenda concerns how these two can coexist. [4, 6, 7]

The core issue is the balance between national representation and commercial opportunity. National teams carry the sport's traditions and remain central to ICC events and international cricket. Franchises can offer players attractive earnings over relatively short commitments, and some players have chosen freelance or hybrid arrangements rather than traditional national contracts. The scale of the difference varies by player, league and board, so comparisons should be made using specific contract figures rather than a universal claim. These choices raise questions about the future of Test cricket and bilateral series. [8, 21–23]

This issue is urgent because leagues in South Africa, the UAE and the United States have expanded within a relatively short period, adding pressure to an already crowded calendar. In early 2024, South Africa's Test tour of New Zealand overlapped with the SA20, and the squad included a number of inexperienced and uncapped players. In 2022, Trent Boult asked to be released from his New Zealand central contract to pursue other opportunities, and New Zealand Cricket agreed. These cases illustrate the tension between international commitments and franchise opportunities, although each player's circumstances differ. [8–10, 23]

Franchise cricket also creates opportunities. Competitions such as the Women's Premier League (WPL) and Women's Big Bash League (WBBL) have created additional professional opportunities for women and attracted investment. Meanwhile, ICC events and the international game remain important to the sport's global profile and to the ICC's development work. Because the ICC does not own or directly operate most franchise leagues, durable solutions are likely to require cooperation among the ICC, national boards, leagues, owners and players. [2, 4, 13, 17]

The guiding question for the committee is: can the ICC protect the long-term health of international cricket without restricting the growth of franchise cricket, and who should bear the cost of achieving the balance?

Intro to T20 and franchise cricket

Twenty20 (T20), is a format of cricket that is played which gives each team 20 overs, and a match lasts around three hours, compared with a full day for an ODI and up to five days for a Test. England's domestic competition introduced it in 2003. The first men's T20 international was Australia vs New Zealand in 2005, and the first ICC Men's T20 World Cup was held in

South Africa in 2007, which was won by India. The short length of the game and big hitting worked well for TV and online audiences, which is why T20 is now the commercial centre of the game. [6]

Challenges to cricket's governing bodies are not new. World Series Cricket, launched by Kerry Packer in the late 1970s, challenged the established structure of the game and helped popularise innovations such as coloured clothing, white balls and day-night matches. In 2007, the Essel Group launched the Indian Cricket League outside the BCCI's control; the BCCI responded by establishing the IPL, and the ICL ended in 2009. These episodes show that commercial change has repeatedly challenged cricket's existing institutions. [6]

The IPL began in 2008 and is built around city-based franchises owned by companies or investment groups. Players are selected through an auction system, subject to league rules and squad limits. The BCCI announced a cumulative media-rights figure of ₹48,390.32 crore for the 2023–2027 cycle. This is the value of a five-year media-rights agreement, not annual revenue or a valuation of the franchises themselves. [12]

Franchise leagues operate under different governance arrangements. Their rules and oversight depend on the relevant national board, league organisers, ownership structure and applicable regulations. For example, the BCCI administers the IPL, while Cricket Australia operates the BBL and the ECB operates The Hundred. League-specific rules on player availability, contracts, overseas-player limits and integrity should be checked against each competition's official regulations. Players may also require permission or a No-Objection Certificate from their national board. The ICC's role is important, but it does not directly own or run most franchise leagues. [5, 18, 29–34]

Additional leagues followed, including the BBL, CPL, WBBL, PSL, The Hundred, SA20, ILT20, Major League Cricket (MLC) and the WPL. Their ownership and commercial structures vary. Some investment groups have interests in teams across multiple competitions, allowing them to share expertise and build international brands; this can also raise questions about concentration of ownership and potential conflicts of interest. Cricket is scheduled to return to the Olympic programme at Los Angeles 2028 in the T20 format, further raising the format's global profile. [7, 29–34]

The Evolving Commercial and Structural Landscape of Franchise Cricket

Franchise cricket has grown substantially since the IPL began in 2008. Men's and women's competitions now occupy windows across the calendar: some are staged during the northern-hemisphere summer, while others take place in the southern-hemisphere summer. Overlapping windows can make it difficult for national boards to schedule bilateral cricket and secure the release of players. Exact dates vary by season, so delegates should consult official competition schedules when preparing country or organisation-specific arguments. [8–11, 29–34]

Media rights are a major commercial asset for the IPL. The BCCI announced that the IPL's 2023–2027 media rights were sold for a cumulative ₹48,390.32 crore. Other leagues operate at different scales, and their income may also include sponsorship, ticketing, merchandise and hospitality; the importance of each stream depends on the league and its published financial information. Reported franchise valuations should be treated carefully because brand-value estimates, sale prices and enterprise valuations measure different things. [12, 14–17]

Ownership structures vary across competitions. Some leagues are operated by national boards, while others combine board oversight with privately owned teams or private investment. MLC, for example, has attracted private investment, while several groups have invested in teams across more than one league. Cross-league ownership can provide access to commercial expertise, coaching networks and player recruitment, but it can also prompt questions about conflicts of interest and the concentration of influence. The details should be checked against each league's current ownership disclosures. [17, 29–34]

The commercial benefits of franchise cricket are not distributed evenly. The IPL has a particularly large media-rights market, while boards operating in smaller markets may have fewer commercial resources and may depend more heavily on ICC support. At the same time, competitions in newer markets, including the United States and the UAE, are part of efforts to grow cricket's audience and infrastructure. Financial comparisons between boards should be based on comparable, audited accounts and the same reporting periods. [2, 4, 12, 21]

Players have adapted to this changing market. Some have sought release from central contracts, while others combine international cricket with franchise commitments. Player organisations, including the Federation of International Cricketers' Associations (FICA), have raised questions about player employment, workload and contract options. Survey findings should be attributed to the specific survey and year, rather than treated as representative of every professional cricketer. [8, 21–23]

Franchise Economy: Commercialisation

Franchise leagues earn money through several streams, including media rights, sponsorship, ticketing, merchandise and hospitality. Media rights are especially important for the IPL: the BCCI announced a cumulative value of ₹48,390.32 crore for its 2023–2027 rights cycle. This is a five-year rights agreement and should not be described as annual income. Claims comparing it with national-board income require comparable financial statements from named boards and the same reporting period. [12, 14, 17, 19]

Sponsorship can be another important source of income. Leagues may sell title sponsorships and teams may sell jersey placements and other partner rights. Ticketing, merchandise and hospitality can also contribute, although their importance differs by competition. Revenue-sharing arrangements are not uniform across cricket: any claim that teams receive central revenue or that such arrangements protect weaker franchises should be supported by the relevant league's published rules or financial disclosures. [17, 29–34]

Franchise values have attracted considerable attention, and women's competitions have also generated major investment. In January 2023, the BCCI announced combined bids of ₹4,669.99 crore for the five WPL franchises. This figure refers to the franchise-rights bids and should not be confused with media-rights value or a later valuation of a team. Reported IPL team values also vary according to whether the source measures brand value, enterprise value or an actual transaction. [13–16]

Player auctions and drafts have increased the visibility of high-value contracts, but comparisons between league earnings and national contracts depend on the player, league, currency, contract period and national-board pay structure. A specific, like-for-like comparison is needed before concluding that a league season pays more than a full year of international cricket. For players from smaller boards, franchise opportunities may be financially significant, which can influence decisions about central contracts and availability. [8, 21–23]

Commercialisation has some clear upsides like more income for the game, better pay, new pathways for women, and revenue that can be reinvested in infrastructure. But it also has costs. A lot of the money is concentrated in a few markets, leagues depend heavily on a handful of broadcasters and sponsors, and the pressure to fill windows with more matches adds to workload and calendar clashes. There are also integrity concerns, since more leagues, more short-term contracts and more betting interest give match-fixers more openings. The committee will need to weigh how much of this growth should be encouraged and who gets a share of it.

Corruption, Match-Fixing and Integrity

Integrity is probably the biggest risk that comes with the growth of franchise cricket. More leagues mean more matches, more short-term contracts and more players earning well in one competition and poorly in another. Every one of those gaps is an opening for fixers. A sport that is watched and bet on as heavily as cricket, especially in South Asia, is always going to attract this kind of interest, and the franchise boom has widened the number of places where it can happen. [5, 24, 28; “biggest” is an evaluative claim, not a measured statistic]

Cricket has a history of integrity controversies. In 2000, South African captain Hansie Cronje admitted involvement in match-fixing-related misconduct, which was examined by the King Commission. In 2010, Pakistan players Salman Butt, Mohammad Asif and Mohammad Amir were implicated in the Lord’s spot-fixing case; the case proceeded through disciplinary and criminal processes. When discussing such cases, delegates should distinguish initial allegations, formal charges, final findings and sanctions, and should cite the relevant official decision for each stage. [25–28]

Franchise leagues have also faced integrity controversies. In 2013, Rajasthan Royals players S. Sreesanth, Ajit Chandila and Ankeet Chavan were arrested in connection with alleged spot-fixing. Separately, the Lodha Committee considered governance issues relating to the IPL, and the Supreme Court-appointed process resulted in two-year suspensions for Chennai Super Kings and Rajasthan Royals. Other leagues have had their own investigations and disciplinary proceedings, which should be described using league-specific rulings or official statements rather than broad generalisations. [27–28]

Responsibility for integrity is divided. The ICC’s Anti-Corruption Unit works within the ICC’s remit and coordinates with members and other relevant bodies. Franchise leagues may operate under the rules of a host board or their own competition framework, so responsibilities and procedures can differ. Delegates should check the relevant code and the league’s relationship with the host board before proposing a universal enforcement model. [5, 24, 29–34]

Several other factors make this harder:

- Tier 3 and unsanctioned leagues. Smaller T10 events, private tournaments and unofficial leagues often have low pay, light monitoring and easy betting markets. Fake leagues have also appeared, such as the reported fake “IPL” in a Gujarat village in 2022, which was streamed online to attract bets. [5, 24]
- Player vulnerability. Players from smaller boards or on short contracts, who earn little or are not paid on time, are easier for fixers to approach. [5, 24]
- Approaches through franchises. Fixers can reach players through team staff, agents or middlemen, not only directly. Multi-league ownership and moving staff add to the difficulty of tracking who is connected to whom. [5, 24]

- Betting and sponsorship. Betting-linked sponsors, surrogate advertising and unregulated streaming sites blur the line between legal and illegal money. Laws differ by country, so what is allowed in one market may be banned in another. [5, 24]
- Reporting and education. Players are expected to report approaches, and failure to report is itself an offence under the code. But young or inexperienced players may not know the rules or may fear the consequences. [5, 24]

The tension for the committee is about authority and resources. A stronger ICC role could close gaps, but the ICC does not run most leagues, and boards and owners may be reluctant to give up control. Smaller boards may also struggle to fund proper integrity units, which means standards could end up uneven even if minimum rules are agreed.

Stakeholders and their Roles

1. **Presidents/Chairmen of Cricket Boards.** As the President/Chairmen of the Cricket Boards you should take a neutral stance on franchise cricket. Franchise cricket has been a huge factor in the growth of cricket and in revenue for many nations, and you should recognise and speak for that. However, it is also still affecting international cricket, including the calendar, player availability and the place of bilateral series, and you should speak for that side too. Your role is to balance both views and look for solutions that protect the national team and international cricket without cutting off the growth and revenue that leagues bring.
2. **CEOs of cricket boards.** As the CEO of the Cricket Board you should take a similar neutral stance. You should speak for how franchise cricket helps the board and the wider game, and how it also affects international cricket. You bring the operational view of contracts, player release, budgets and scheduling to the discussion.
3. **Franchise league owners.** As the Owner of major franchise leagues around the world, you should speak completely in support of franchise cricket. Your role is to talk about the opportunities it brings, such as investment, higher player pay, new audiences, new stadiums and academies, and growth for the game in new countries. You should argue for your leagues' autonomy, stability and growth.
4. **Franchise team owners.** As the Owner and stakeholder of Major Franchise teams which compete in leagues around the world, you should take a similar stance to the league owners. You should speak in support of franchise cricket and of the opportunities it creates, including the capital, expertise and global reach that you bring, and you should defend the freedom to invest across borders and protect their commercial rights.

Conclusion: The Central Problem

References and Further Reading

Franchise cricket has brought investment, new audiences and opportunities in new markets, but it can also put pressure on the international calendar. The overlap between the SA20 and South Africa's 2024 Test tour of New Zealand became a prominent example of the difficulty of balancing domestic league commitments with international selection. Boards with smaller commercial markets may also find it harder to compete with the remuneration available in major leagues. [9–10, 21, 23]

A 2022 report by the Indian Express summarised findings from a FICA player survey, including figures on free-agent and hybrid-contract arrangements among the survey respondents. These figures should be attributed to that survey and not generalised to all professional cricketers. Players such as Trent Boult have publicly pursued greater flexibility to participate in franchise

cricket, illustrating the changing relationship between central contracts and league opportunities. Any direct comparison of league earnings and national pay should use named players' published contract terms and a clearly stated period. [8, 21]

Smaller and newer leagues raise questions about regulatory capacity, player protection and integrity systems. Risks can arise where oversight, education, reporting channels or payment protections are weak, but these concerns should be assessed competition by competition rather than assumed of all lower-tier leagues. The claim that 61% of active ICC anti-corruption investigations are linked to Associate Member countries has not been verified against a specific public ICC report and is therefore omitted from this version. Delegates should use official investigation announcements, disciplinary decisions and league regulations when discussing individual cases. [5, 24, 28–34]

That leaves the council with their central problem. Franchise cricket pays the players, creates new markets and grows the game. It also takes players, calendar space and money away from the international game which is what gives cricket its identity and which in turn funds the development of the game in the Associate world. The ICC rules were written for international cricket and the new commercial centre of the game is largely outside those rules. As members of this council, you will have to work out how much to regulate, how to share the money, how to protect the calendar and how to keep the game honest without in any way undermining the growth that the leagues have brought. A viable outcome would be one where franchise and international cricket can co-exist with clearly defined windows, minimum standards for the leagues, fair treatment of the players and support for the boards and the Associates who rely on the international game.

References and Further Reading

Sources are numbered to match the in-text citations throughout this guide. Official ICC, national-board and league sources should be prioritised for current rules, membership and financial figures.

Prepared for the SOMUN 2026 ICC Background Guide, “Addressing the Challenges and Opportunities Presented by the Rise of Franchise Cricket.” Sources are grouped by topic and include direct links. Use primary sources for official rules, membership, announcements and financial figures; use reputable reporting for independent context and transactions. Accessed 23 October 2026.

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G. Recommended additional primary sources for league-specific details

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30. Cricket Australia. Official website and annual reports. Available at: https://www.cricket.com.au/
31. Cricket South Africa. Official website. Available at: https://cricket.co.za/
32. Major League Cricket. Official website. Available at: https://www.majorleaguecricket.com/
33. Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB). Official website. Available at: https://www.pcb.com.pk/
34. Cricket West Indies. Official website. Available at: https://www.windiescricket.com/